

TOPIC: WOMEN AND YOUTH; EXISTING CAPACITIES FOR INTERACTION AND COOPERATION

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ABSTRACT

With equal opportunities, alternative sponsorship of projects funding, empowerment; women and youths can be agents of change for sustainable socio-economic development, and security around the world. Lack of these considerations is what hindered the achievement of the full potential of the millennium development goals. It is through alternative funding of projects, passionate implementation of same for women and youths that the economic empowerment and market development which seeks sustainable improvement in the quality of life of the rural population by strengthening low-income rural markets, stimulating local economic development and diversifying livelihood opportunities; would contribute towards the achievement of Africa's developmental goals of inclusive economic growth and poverty alleviation.

INTRODUCTION

Why Women Empowerment is Essential for Sustainable Development.

Gender equality is a moral imperative whether you are in government, business, non-governmental organization (NGO) or research institute. Its simply the "right thing to do".

Gender bias is still deeply embedded in cultures, economies, political and social institutions around the world. Women and girls unacceptable levels of discrimination and abuse, which is not only wrong but also prevents decision making.

More organizations need to understand and address internal imbalances and proactively seek to do in delivering their business. Barbara Stocking, former chief executive of Oxfam GB, writes in the book: " Leadership from the top is essential but values of gender equality have to permeate the whole organization.

Women are key managers of natural resources and powerful agents of change, women are often more directly dependent on natural resources, with responsibility for the unpaid work of securing food, water, fuel and shelter for their household. "Not just victims, women have been and can be central actors in pathways to sustainability and green transformation", according to the contribution from Iyla Mehta and Melissa Leach.

Women are more vulnerable to environmental degradation and climate change but also have different perspectives, concerns and ideas for change. Until these are taken on board, with women empowered to play a full part in decision making at all levels, environmental sustainability will remain a distant goal.

Yet women's empowerment must not mean simply adding to their business of responsibilities or building expectations of women as "sustainability saviors".

Diane Elson, an adviser to UN women argues in her contribution that "the disproportionate responsibility that women bear for carrying out unpaid work is an important constraint on their capacity to realize their rights... Both women and men need time to care for their families and communities, and time free from such care".

In most societies and economies, women's unpaid work and nature's services are accounted for and therefore not valued properly in our economic, political or social systems.

Julie Nelson argues that "women and nature are largely invisible in mainstream economic... one would search in vain in the core models of economics for any inkling of where the materials used in production came from, or where it goes... for a discussion of where people come from, or where they go when they are broken or used up. When considered at all, women and nature are treated as passive 'resources'".

Diane Elson, Vandana Shiva and other contributors argue that we need a transformation in our economic thinking and new definitions of progress. Across polities, business and media, we need to create a system based on different values, with equality and sustainability and it's core.

BODY

In the rural areas, women and youths have experienced more of poverty due to the prevailing culture which requires women to stay back and keep home and youths that are not yet of age were required to help in house chores, and street trading. This disregards the import of "training a girl-child and training a nation". Many could not be schooled, while some drop out due to lack of resources to train them. The men therefore were regarded as breadwinners. With increasing enlightenment, women now see the need to be engaged in order to contribute their quota to the home and thus improve their status as well as the family in general. The effect of poverty is high on women and youth (moghadam, 2005; yoshikwa & beardslee, 2005), therefore addressing the problem of poverty has to focus on an inclusive Programme that will impact the life of the two groups. As a result of poverty, both women and youth pass through emotional, mental and behavioral trauma. The long run effect is accentuated on the fact that women statistics is high (BOS, 2010), their contribution to the economic strength of the nation, if compared should be commensurate. Unfortunately, women are still far behind in the stream of nation development (OJO, 2011) as their positions are still being agitated for even in governance. The needs of the poor

vary widely from financial, knowledge, health, security, to home needs, shelter, even childlessness, among others. Often, across cultures women spend close to 15-18 hours with the off-springs during these times they bear sudden and immediate needs when the household head is not immediately available or where the women (widow, single mother) is the head of such home. Equally, such widow is seen to have started carrying the burden that two people normally should carry. Determining the need of such mother in like with possible help would have been generalized. In the same vain, a woman under relative poverty situation is also helped generally. Streamlining a general approach that weighs the needs with help provision could be meaningful in the kind of empowerment made available.

Poverty is conceived as a situation of depravity, hunger, helplessness, disease, increase in crime, child mortality rates, political instability, corruption dysfunctional governance and lack in meeting essential needs by individuals. We are seeing now that poverty is a prime driver of violent extremism, breeding and intensifying conflicts worldwide. The approach to progress on reducing poverty, involves focusing on a long time action plan in partnership with beneficiary nations. Further action included reducing child-mortality rate, increasing primary school environment for boys and girls, improving maternal health care and provision of needful infrastructures such as good portable water for drinking.

Entrepreneurship requires creating new ideas, improving on existing ones and being dynamic in the approach to executing the business. Enhancing and sustaining the level of attainment require educating the poor women and youths and supporting them financially to get to the level of continued sustenance of set of goals. Situating equity and inequality within the capability approach the drive should be focused on active participation of the identified or representative poor to indicate required area of need and individual passion or skill for effective result.

Leong(2013) suggested that what is required of women is to take a leap into setting up a business of which they have personal convictions and exercise the will and power to make it work. Focusing on who to be as an entrepreneur (producer or service provider), capital funds available may not be easily forthcoming.

Many low income countries lack proper social protection laws, which despite overall economic growth, results in a vicious circle of poverty. Where basic human needs remain unmet. Volunteers are well-placed to support poverty reduction strategies and create pathways to economic empowerment of women and youth.

Many households in countries with high poverty rates are vulnerable to exploitation due to their limited access to employment, made worse by poorly enforced labour laws, inadequate political and trade-union representation, and general economic deficits. These factors when combined can force entire families to spend their lives in neglected circumstances. It is women and youth who more often find themselves in such precarious situations with no other options but temporary, low-income and low-quality jobs. In the worst of circumstances, those most at risk may become subject to forced labour while others who have the means, opt to migrate in search of income, leaving their families and communities behind.

Throughout the world, women represent the largest share of the people living in poverty. Social inequality, access to resources, and gender roles greatly influence the distribution of poverty, burdening women disproportionately with the negative outcomes of insufficient national economic performance or distribution of wealth. Feminized poverty can be addressed by providing women with access to education, economic autonomy, and developing pro-poor and gender-sensitive development strategies to make crucial steps towards global eradication of poverty. The need to equally invest in youth cannot be overstated.

Alleviating poverty through entrepreneurship education. Entrepreneurship through education seeks to provide students with the knowledge, skills and motivation to encourage entrepreneurial success in a variety of settings. Entrepreneurship education is known as a specialized knowledge that inculcates in learners the traits of risk-taking, innovation, arbitrage and coordination of factors of production for the purpose of creating new products or services for new and existing users within human communities. Entrepreneurial education has to increase entrepreneurial self-efficacy, self-employment, and risk-taking attitude of the entrepreneur. Entrepreneurship education creates enormous business enterprise skills to grasp the opportunities for starting new entrepreneurial activities. Entrepreneurship education is one way of addressing poverty reduction as there is strong empirical evidence suggesting that economic growth over time is necessary for poverty reduction. Entrepreneurship boosts economic growth, enhances educational attainment and increases the rate of economic growth.

Alleviating poverty through Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises. Micro, small & medium enterprises (MS&MEs) can play an important role in developing the economic growth of a country as well as alleviating poverty through new jobs creation and providing income for the people. MS & MEs cannot only help during the period of economic growth but also in economic recession.

Alleviating poverty through social entrepreneurship. Social entrepreneurship is now creating new business model. It also bridges an important gap between business and social action. Social entrepreneurship, commonly defined as entrepreneurial activity with an embedded social purpose. Social entrepreneurship is perceived to be about applying the expertise, talents and resources of entrepreneurs to the variety of problems developing countries face, such as education, health, personal safety and security, poverty alleviation, social advancement, environmental sustainability e.t.c. Social entrepreneurship is used to refer to the rapidly growing number of organizations that have created models for efficiently catering to basic human needs that existing markets and institutions have failed

to satisfy. It combines the resourcefulness of traditional entrepreneurship with a mission to change society. It offers insights that may stimulate ideas for more socially acceptable and sustainable business strategies and organizational forms, because, it contributes directly to internationally recognized sustainable development goals, social entrepreneurship may also encourage established corporations to take on greater social responsibility. Social entrepreneurship can pave a way for the future that allow coming generations to satisfy their needs better than we are able to satisfy even the basic needs of [today's](#) population.

Alleviating poverty through women entrepreneurship. Entrepreneurship is [today](#) considered to be a relevant vehicle for economic development and women contribute to it significantly worldwide in 2010, 187 million women were involved in creating and operating enterprises, meaning that almost 42% of entrepreneurs in the world were women. On the other hand, however, women have a number of parental duties and inflexible household obligations which they try to effectively combine to maintain a balance between running a business and running a home. However, women to date represent an important engine of economic growth for developing countries as it has a leading role in generating productive work, achieving gender equality and reducing poverty. Global entrepreneurship in 2014 showed that women perform 66% of work globally and produce more than 50% of food globally and these women turn locally available raw materials into processed and finished goods for sale, therefore making them innovators in business. Female entrepreneurship can be divided into two categories; the traditional generation of entrepreneurial women, concentrated around business involving household services, which require reduced skills and experience; on the other hand modern generation, more actively involved in businesses more oriented towards profit and creating new markets. Women entrepreneurship is becoming gradually popular across the globe. The participation of women is progressively being observed as one of the major contributors in economic growth. Regardless of their involvement in small or medium scale enterprises or in the informal or formal sectors, their contribution to output and value addition is considerable. Women entrepreneurship is not only necessary for their economic survival but also for strengthening the social system.

RECOMMENDATION

In Nigeria, there is hope for rapid improvement as youth and women respond fast to Programs that create an enabling environment for enhancing their capabilities. Therefore, Sponsorship of projects for sustainable socio-economic development can be achieved through these objectives; to create a platform for economic empowerment, to increase self confidence and self dependency, to create employment opportunities by providing credit assistance, to increase the capacity of women in marketing, to create access to public health facilities, to ensure deserted women have rights and protection. So also across policies, business and the media a system should be created based on different values with equality and sustainability at its core. We need a transformation in our economic thinking and need definitions of progress across politics. Volunteers should be well placed to support poverty reduction strategies and create pathways to economic empowerment for women and youth.

CONCLUSION

From this research, it can be concluded that women and youths have the capacity for interaction and cooperation in the sense that women are key managers of natural resources, they are powerful agents of change and are often more directly dependent on natural resources, with responsibility for the unpaid work of securing food, water, fuel and shelter for their household. So also, this study shows that poverty is a prime driver of violent extension, breeding and intensifying conflicts worldwide. It also shows that women represent the largest share of the people living in poverty. This study thus, highlights statistics pertaining to inclusive growth in the area of women leading a safe and healthy life, youth empowerment and improving living standard in two Asian countries (India and China) that have experienced inclusive growth. In Nigeria and Iran, in addressing poverty, had been encouraging self-dependence rather than citizens waiting on government to create employment or even employing them. This can only be achieved through entrepreneurial endeavors that engage them productively; addressing the challenges of poverty requires not only, but combined educational approach that involves classroom and vocational/entrepreneurial training. What this requires is a responsive sector to educate and enable relevant participants. This is therefore in addition to health, security, and shelter and so on, a total education of women and youth which involves classroom and entrepreneurial orientation to pre-empt unemployment for school leavers and entrepreneurial empowerment for mothers, widows and youths is the answer to Irans and Nigerias poverty challenges.